When Barbosa, a Portuguese officer in India for fifteen years, visited Vijayanagar in c. 1515, Krishnadevaraya was king. Barbosa describes great palaces, buildings and many water tanks ‘in which is reared abundance of fish’. He was struck by the city’s ‘great traffic and endless number of merchants and wealthy men’, including visitors ‘to whom the King allows such freedom that every man may come and go and live according to his own creed, without suffering any annoyance and without enquiry whether he is a Christian, Jew, Moor or Heathen’.[15]

The markets sell diamonds and pearls in ‘great quantities’, and iron, copper, mercury, vermilion, opium, scented materials, pepper, fine textiles and cheaper brocades from China and Alexandria. To groom themselves, elite men grind up sandalwood, aloeswood, camphor, musk and saffron, knead it with rosewater and anoint themselves with it. They wear ‘certain clothes as a girdle below, wound very tightly in many folds, and short white shirts of cotton or silk or coarse brocade, which are gathered between the thighs but open in front’, with turbans, or caps of silk or brocade, earrings with pearls and rings with precious stones. These foppish gents of Vijayanagar might be ‘accompanied by pages walking behind them with swords in their hands’ and sometimes a silk umbrella in the hot sun or rain.

